


**BAHUBALI**
**63 Insights into Jainism**
*by Devdutt Pattanaik*
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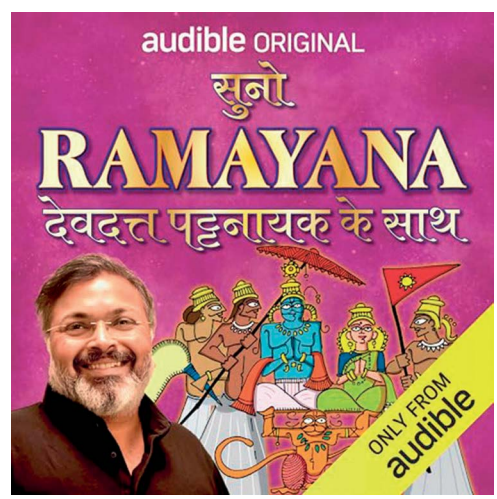
Devdutt Pattanaik has never been shy of expressing an opinion, even if it's an unconventional one. This is perhaps his greatest strength as a mythologist, storyteller and public speaker. A doctor by training, he started writing while still working in the pharmaceutical and healthcare industries. His first book was *Shiva: An Introduction* (1997). Eventually becoming a full-time writer, Pattanaik must have written about every major god under the sun by now.

Several of his works have challenged conventional interpretations of the epics or highlighted marginalised characters and narratives. These include *The Man Who Was a Woman and Other Queer Tales from Hindu Lore* (2002), *The Pregnant King* (2008), *Sita: An Illustrated Retelling of the Ramayana* (2013), *Shikhandi: And Other Tales They Don't Tell You* (2014) and *Olympus: An Indian Retelling of Greek Mythology* (2016), which drew praise from Neil Gaiman. Pattanaik illustrates his own books. In tandem, he has written books for younger readers. He has even penned a series of management books drawing on Hindu mythology. The man is nothing if not productive.

For his new podcast on Audible—*Suno Ramayana Devdutt Pattanaik ke Saath*—Pattanaik adopts an endearing 'Hinglish' style of narration. "It works best for Indian audiences," he says. "Also, some concepts sound better in Hindi. For example, saying '*bhog*' and '*yog*' connects with audiences, but in English, they take on the meanings of 'indulgence' and 'restraint'."

While the podcast's 12 episodes follow a chronological order, ranging from 'Birth' to 'Marriage', 'Abduction', 'War' and so on, each episode also addresses a specific theme. "I know that I'm bringing my brand of storytelling to the audience and they're expecting an analysis while telling the story. This is a very old Indian technique. You tell the story, but you also draw attention to the complex layers of meaning," says Pattanaik. "I have drawn attention to things that people normally overlook. That's my speciality; I like to give people a lot of 'aha' moments." The tone is genial. As Pattanaik says about the podcast right in the beginning of the first episode, "*samvaad ke liye hai, vivaad ke liye nahin* (it is for dialogue, not dispute)."

As for recording the episodes, Pattanaik's method is to make notes but always do it extempore, "because when you read from a piece of paper, it sounds scripted, [and] the audience doesn't connect with you emotionally...the rough edges make it better." He does record more than what actually makes it past the final edit, speaking for 45-50 minutes, but not more than a podcast a day. The lengths of the final episodes vary from 16 to 28 minutes.




Throughout *Suno Ramayana*, Pattanaik draws attention to the many Ramayanas in existence, demonstrating that no single version is primary. "Originally," he says, "the Ramayana was designed to counter the Buddhist worldview, which valourised monasticism and renunciation. It was popularised by kings and this form is what reached Southeast Asia. What is significant, in Southeast Asian versions, is the absence of emotion and the absence of what, in India, we call *bhakti* today. *Bhakti* emerged only 500 years earlier, by which time sea travel to Southeast Asia had stopped. In later regional narratives, we see an emotional connect.... I think people need to understand how stories change over time, what remains constant and what transforms."

Pattanaik makes no claims to academic rigour, preferring to simplify and elucidate the complex narrative threads for a broad-based audience. "I am talking to a 21st-century audience, and I want to make the Ramayana relevant to them. An Audible podcast is not an academic exercise. It's designed to make the general listener feel that they have learned something from the podcast. Thus, their insecurities, their biases, their issues, form the bedrock on which I build the Ramayana." For Pattanaik, the Ramayana remains relevant for his contemporary audience "be-